



Death in the desert

Predators often strike from above, but Grant's golden mole attacks from below. This one is feeding on a locust, which it has tracked while "swimming" beneath desert sand. The mole picks up on vibrations and can sense the movement of insects and lizards several yards away. Golden moles dig using their front claws, which are like a set of shovels. When the sand is dry, they do not leave tunnels—the sand collapses as soon as they move on.

*Extra-thick
exoskeleton
on head*



*Reinforced
front leg*

Armored burrowers

Mole crickets feed on roots and are specially reinforced for burrowing underground. Their heads are armored, and their front legs are short and strong, with clawlike ends highly adept at burrowing and swimming. They spend most of their lives hidden away, but the adults usually have working wings. On summer nights, they leave their burrows and fly off in search of a mate.



Tunnel squad

With their tiny eyes and almost hairless skin, naked mole rats are Africa's strangest burrowing mammals. They feed on the roots of desert plants and dig with their giant incisor teeth. They often tunnel through the insides of nutritious, giant plant roots, or tubers, while keeping the outside layers alive, so they will continue to grow. When naked mole rats dig, they form "chain gangs," with one digging and several more clearing away the soil, passing it back from one to another.

Disappearing trick

Most clams are slow movers, but the razor clam is one of the fastest burrowers in the animal world. It lives on coasts near the low-tide mark, with its slender shell upright in the sand. If in danger, a razor clam can use its powerful foot to dig down to a safe depth of 3 ft (1 m) in under 10 seconds, which is much faster than a human with a shovel.

